in Hindu scriptures gave educated Hindus great pride in their tradition and culture.

Contribution of Annie Besant


Annie Besant

In India the movement became further popular with the election of Annie Besant (1847–1933) as its president after the death of Olcott. She played a role in Indian nationalist politics, and formed the Home Rule League demanding home rule to India on the lines of Ireland. Annie Besant spread Theosophical ideas through her newspapers called *New India* and *Commonweal*.

5.3 Anti-Caste Movements

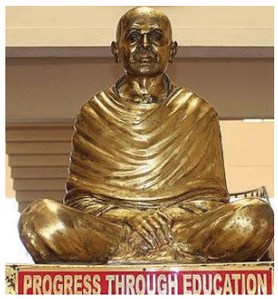
(a) Jyotiba Phule

Jyotiba Govindrao Phule was born in 1827 in Maharashtra. He opened the first school for "untouchables" in 1852 in Poona. He launched the Satyashodak Samaj (Truth-Seekers Society) in 1870 to stir the non-Brahman masses to self-respect. Phule opposed child marriage and supported widow remarriage. Jyotiba and his wife Savitribai Phule devoted their lives for the uplift of the depressed classes and women. Jotiba opened orphanages and homes for widows. His work, *Gulamgiri* (Slavery) is an important text that summarized many of his radical ideas.


Jyotiba Phule and Savitribai Phule

(b) Narayana Guru

Born to poor parents in Kerala, Narayana Guru (1854–1928) evolved into a poet and scholar in Malayalam, Tamil and Sanskrit. Disturbed by the terrible caste tyranny, that the lower caste people suffered, he dedicated his whole life for the betterment of the oppressed. He set up the Sri Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam, an organization to work for the uplift of the "depressed classes". He established a grand temple at Aruvipuram and dedicated it to all. Thinkers and writers such as Kumaran Asan and Dr Palpu were influenced by his ideas and carried forward the movement.



Narayana Guru

(c) Ayyankali

Ayyankali was born in 1863 at Venganoor in Thiruvananthapuram then in the princely state of Travancore. The discrimination he faced as a child turned him into a leader of an anti-caste movement and who later fought for basic rights including access to public spaces and entry to schools.


Ayyankali

Inspired by Sree Narayana Guru, Ayyankali founded the Sadhu Jana Paripalana Sangam (Association for the Protection of the Poor) in 1907.

5.4 Islamic Reforms

After the suppression of great revolt of 1857 Indian Muslims looked to Western culture with suspicion. The community feared that Western education, Western culture and Western ideas would endanger their religion. Therefore only a small section of Muslims accepted the new avenues for modern education.

Sir Sayyid Ahmed Khan

Born in Delhi into a noble Muslim family, Sayyid Ahmed Khan thought that lack

05_History_Unit_5_EM.indd 57 1/4/2022 8:02:20 PM